

Where Birds Live

BIRDS LIVE IN EVERY CORNER OF THE GLOBE. They have spread so far because they can fly from one place to another, live on a variety of foods, and maintain a constant body temperature in most types of weather.

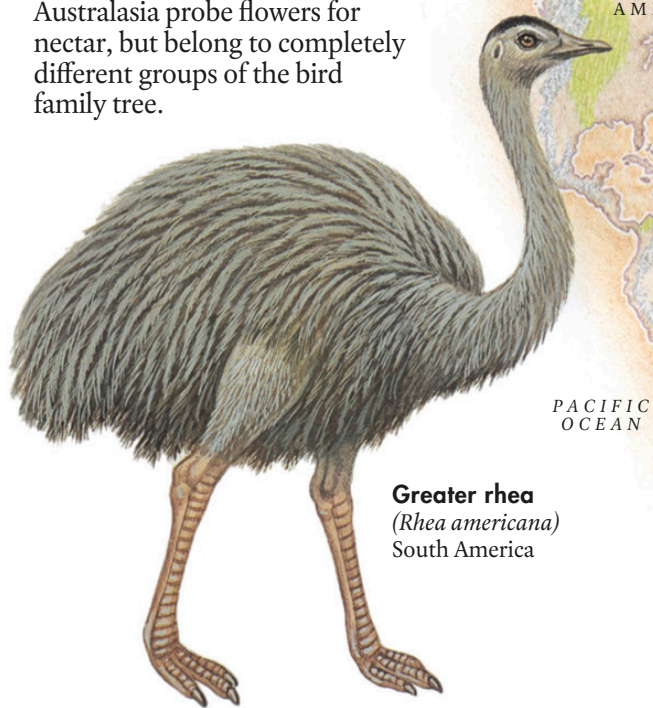
The place where a bird lives is called its habitat. This is rather like its “home address.” A bird’s habitat must provide food, shelter, and somewhere to nest. Some birds, such as the barn owl, can live in a range of habitats from woodland to scrub; others are more specialized (toucans, for example, live only in the

rainforests of Central and South America). Some birds stay permanently in one habitat, while others move away—migrate—at certain times of year. There are an increasing number of human-made habitats, such as houses, parks, and backyards. Some of the most common birds, such as starlings and sparrows, have adapted to live in these new habitats near people.

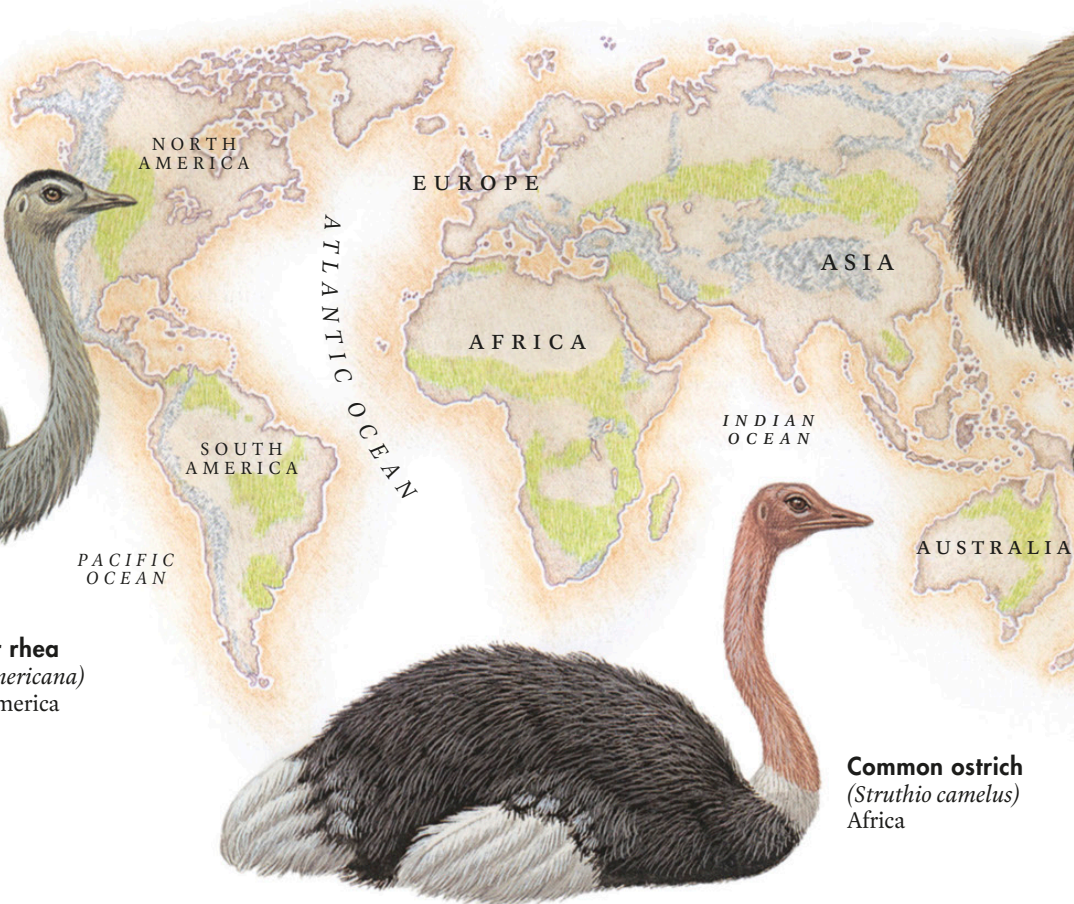
The main types of bird habitat around the world are shown at the bottom of these pages.

Look-alikes

Birds that live in similar habitats or feed on similar things have often evolved to look similar. The map shows the world’s grasslands and three related birds that live in these habitats in different parts of the world: the rhea, ostrich, and emu. Each is flightless, but has evolved strong running legs to escape danger. Sometimes birds can end up looking similar, even though they are not related. This is called convergent evolution. For example, hummingbirds from America and honeyeaters from Australasia probe flowers for nectar, but belong to completely different groups of the bird family tree.



Greater rhea
(*Rhea americana*)
South America



Common emu
(*Dromaius novaehollandiae*)
Australia



Common ostrich
(*Struthio camelus*)
Africa



Polar and tundra

The Arctic in the north and the Antarctic in the south are among the harshest environments on Earth. Freezing temperatures, howling gales, and long dark winters mean that few birds can live there, but seabirds nest along the coasts in summer. Surrounding the Arctic is a cold, treeless region called the tundra. In summer, birds such as waders, ducks, and geese flock there to raise their young as there are few predators, and plenty of food and light.

Find out more: pages 8–9, 58–59



Taiga

Coniferous trees such as pine, fir, and spruce grow in a huge forest called the taiga, which stretches across the top of North America, Europe, and Asia. The taiga is one of the largest forest areas in the world. Most coniferous trees have needlelike leaves that stay on the trees all year. Birds feed on the tree cones and help spread the tree seeds. Summers are usually mild, but winters are bitterly cold. Many birds fly south to warmer places in winter.

Find out more: pages 12–13, 28–29



Temperate deciduous woodlands

Deciduous, or broad-leaved, woodlands grow south of the dark conifer woods. Many of the trees, such as oak and beech, lose their leaves in winter, but there is plenty of rainfall all year, and the climate is generally mild. These woodlands provide plenty of food and nesting places for birds in spring and summer.

Find out more: pages 12–13, 52–53



Grasslands

Grasslands occur where the climate is too dry and the soil is too poor for most trees to survive. Fires are common in this habitat, but the grasses grow back. Grasslands provide plenty of food for seed- and insect-eating birds. Tropical grasslands, such as the African savanna, are hot all year with long dry spells. Temperate grasslands, such as the South American pampas, are cooler, with hot summers and long, cold winters.

Find out more: pages 23, 38–39